

Strokes (Cerebrovascular Disease) in Dogs and Cats

What is it?

Cerebrovascular disease affects the **blood supply to the brain**. The most common form is a **stroke** — blood flow to part of the brain is interrupted by a **blockage** (ischemic stroke) or **bleeding** (hemorrhagic stroke).

Causes and risk factors

- **Underlying disease:** kidney disease, heart disease, high blood pressure, thyroid or adrenal disorders
- **Blood clotting disorders** (blood that clots too easily)
- Brain tumors; head trauma
- **Older age**

Signs

Strokes in pets look different from strokes in people. Signs come on **suddenly** and depend on the area of the brain affected:

- Head tilt, loss of balance, circling
- Abnormal eye movements
- Weakness on one side of the body
- Sudden collapse
- Behavior change, sudden blindness
- Seizures

Diagnosis

Seek veterinary care right away if you suspect a stroke.

- **Neurological exam**

- **MRI** (or CT) to identify the affected area
- **Blood tests** and **blood pressure** measurement to find underlying causes
- Sometimes spinal fluid analysis

Treatment

- **Supportive care:** fluids, nutrition, nursing care
- **Treating underlying conditions:** heart or kidney disease, high blood pressure
- **Medications** as needed: anti-seizure drugs, drugs to reduce brain swelling
- **Physical rehabilitation** to regain mobility

Recovery and prognosis

Many pets **recover significantly**, especially with prompt care. Most improvement happens in the first few weeks, but recovery can take days to months. Some pets keep permanent deficits (such as a head tilt). Physical therapy and regular rechecks improve outcomes.

Reducing the risk

- Regular check-ups, including blood pressure in older pets
- Managing chronic conditions as prescribed
- Healthy weight, regular exercise and a balanced diet

Seek emergency care for

Sudden neurological signs, collapse or inability to walk, seizures, rapid eye movements or severe disorientation.